



## Our struggles have stories



The struggles we face as adults often have roots in childhood adaptations. These adaptations or strategies were critical to minimize threats and ensure survival, especially in environments where parts of ourselves were criticized or rejected by parents. If making mistakes lead to harsh parental criticism, you may have adopted a "perfectionistic" strategy to regain positive attention (ie..g, love) from your caregiver. As children, we develop "protector" parts to shield the parts of us—referred to as "exiles"—that were seen as unacceptable. This echoes Internal Family Systems (IFS) therapy, which explains that individuals develop internal systems with parts that protect the self from being overwhelmed by painful emotions.

Without conscious awareness, adults can re-enact patterns from their own upbringing. The way we were parented can shape how we unconsciously interact with our children or partners. For example, we may inadvertently attempt to shut down traits in our children that were rejected in us, perpetuating cycles of emotional suppression.

**Exercise: Write down on a piece of paper...**  
**"I struggle with the \_\_\_\_\_ part of me.**  
**This struggle has a story."**

MAKE A LIST YOUR PROTECTOR  
AND EXILE PARTS.



### Protectors

As parents, we may have "protector" parts whose jobs are to guard against the emotional pain or vulnerabilities formed in childhood. These protectors help us avoid feelings that were too painful to address when we were younger, but they may not always serve us or our children in healthy ways. Here are some common examples of protector roles or behaviors that parents may adopt:

- 1.) Perfectionist Parent
- 2.) Overprotective Parent
- 3.) The Dismissive Parent
- 4.) The Authoritarian Parent
- 5.) The Workaholic Parent



### Exiles

We also have wounded aspects of ourselves that were often repressed or pushed away during childhood due to experiences of pain, shame, or fear. These parts hold emotions, desires, or traits that were unacceptable in our early environments. These parts hold painful memories and unresolved feelings and are often "exiled" by protector parts to avoid discomfort or emotional overwhelm.

1. The Not-Good-Enough Child
2. The Helpless Child
3. The Sensitive Child
4. The Fearful Child
5. The Unloved Child

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# Heal Those Childhood Wounds, Dear One.



## Step 1.

### **Parent Consciously.**

Start by recognizing the behaviors or emotional patterns that arise in your parenting, especially in moments of stress or conflict. Notice if you feel the urge to dismiss, control, or withdraw emotionally.



## Step 2.

### **Use the Pause Button.**

Remind yourself that your child is not the source of these feelings—those emotions belong to your own past experiences. When you notice yourself reacting strongly, pause and ask yourself, “Is this reaction really about my child, or is it about something in me?” This can help you begin to separate past wounds from the present situation.



## Step 3.

### **Wear Your Oxygen Mask.**

Parenting can bring up a lot of old wounds, and it’s common to feel guilt or frustration when you react in ways you don’t want to. Wear your oxygen mask by practicing self-compassion and reminding yourself that you are doing the best you can with the emotional tools you have, and that healing is a gradual process. Do self care practices to restore your sense of well-being and nurture those exiled parts.

## Step 4.

**Do your work.** You can’t change your past, but you can change your present. Revisiting painful memories can be a path toward healing. As you process these experiences, you may find that you can let go of anger, fear, or resentment, which can positively impact your interactions with your child. By openly addressing your story and showing how you’ve worked through difficulties, you model resilience and emotional intelligence for your child.

## Step 5.

**Commit Daily.** Verbalize to yourself on a daily basis, “I am good parent”, actually increases motivation and the likelihood of following through on value-centered goals of behavior change. Even involving your children in your commitment to change fosters a supportive family environment and teaches them the value of accountability and respect. Put a stinky note on the fridge that says “We use kind words to each other” reinforces positive engagement among one another.